generalisation and not all the Byzantine rulers were as devoted. But, in the West, the Church, with its own State and an effective religious infrastructure, was, from early in its history, a power in its own right and it was secular rulers who needed the Church to provide validation of their rule. In other words, in the West, the Church was independent of the State, although the reverse was not necessarily the case. In the Byzantine world, it was not: the Church and the State were more or less the same and this was seen as a strength and a virtue.[18]

This relationship between politics and religion in the Orthodox world led to the creation of national Churches and also to a degree of isolation from the rest of the world. It also enabled Orthodox nations to survive Ottoman rule by means of semi-autonomous structures within the Ottoman state when Byzantium (and other lands in the Balkans) was conquered by the Ottomans. But Ottoman rule also meant that these Orthodox Churches and their respective societies were 'protected' from (or deprived of) the influence of Reformation and the Enlightenment, which together with Christianity were of central importance for the formation of Western civilisation.[19] Even today, this ethnocentrism (or nationalism) of Orthodox Churches remains one of its key problems, echoing in politics in Montenegro, North Macedonia and Ukraine. In all these cases, newly independent nations had to invest a lot of energy to get an ecclesiastical acknowledgement of their independence, contested by other Orthodox nations with their own national Orthodox churches.

What about the relationship of Byzantium with the rest of Eastern Europe? Byzantine influence was limited to the south-east and the far east of Europe – it never managed to establish itself in the areas of modern Hungary, Poland or the Czech Republic, i.e. Central Europe. The centre of the Byzantine world was originally, of course, Greece, and it is the Orthodox tradition that connects that country with other Eastern European countries. (It is the experience of long rule by the Ottomans which, in another sense, connects it to the Balkans.) Kievan Rus, centred in modern Ukraine, was also influenced by the Byzantine tradition, but, after the fall of Byzantium, it was Russia which took over the role of the centre of the Orthodox world. Moscow became the 'third Rome' and, with its rising military strength, Russia became the ultimate regional power even in areas where Byzantium never managed to establish itself – in Eastern Europe proper. Today, these